DNL HISTORY-GEOGRAPHY · TERMINALE BFI · M. ROS

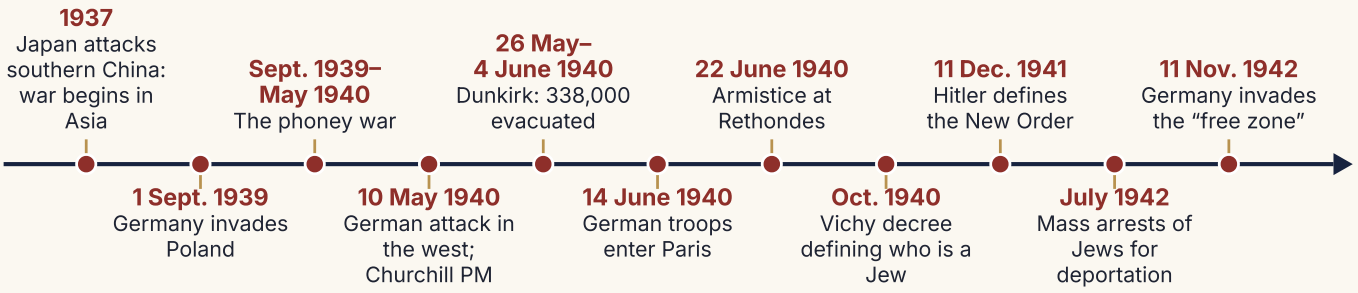
H3 World War Two

Theme 1 — The fragilisation of democracy, totalitarianism and WWII (1929–1945)

Objective. Assess the nature of the New European Order that Nazi Germany built through war, and the purposes it served — starting with the invasion and occupation of France.

Partial sheet: only what has been taught in class so far. Still to come: II The quest for Lebensraum in Eastern Europe · III The Nazi racial policy: towards the genocide.

Ten dates to know



The big picture

The Second World War was the ideological crucible of the twentieth century. It began before 1939 — in 1937 with Japan's attack on China, for historians such as Robert Frank — and ended with about 60 million dead. For the Nazis, conquest was the chance to build a New European Order: a continent organised by race, emptied of its Jews, colonised in the East, cleansed of communism, unified as one economic space and drained to supply Germany's total war. This chapter studies that order through three cases: the invasion of Western Europe, the quest for Lebensraum in the East, and the racial policy that led to genocide.

KEY ISSUES

- Assess the aims of the New European Order (WW2).

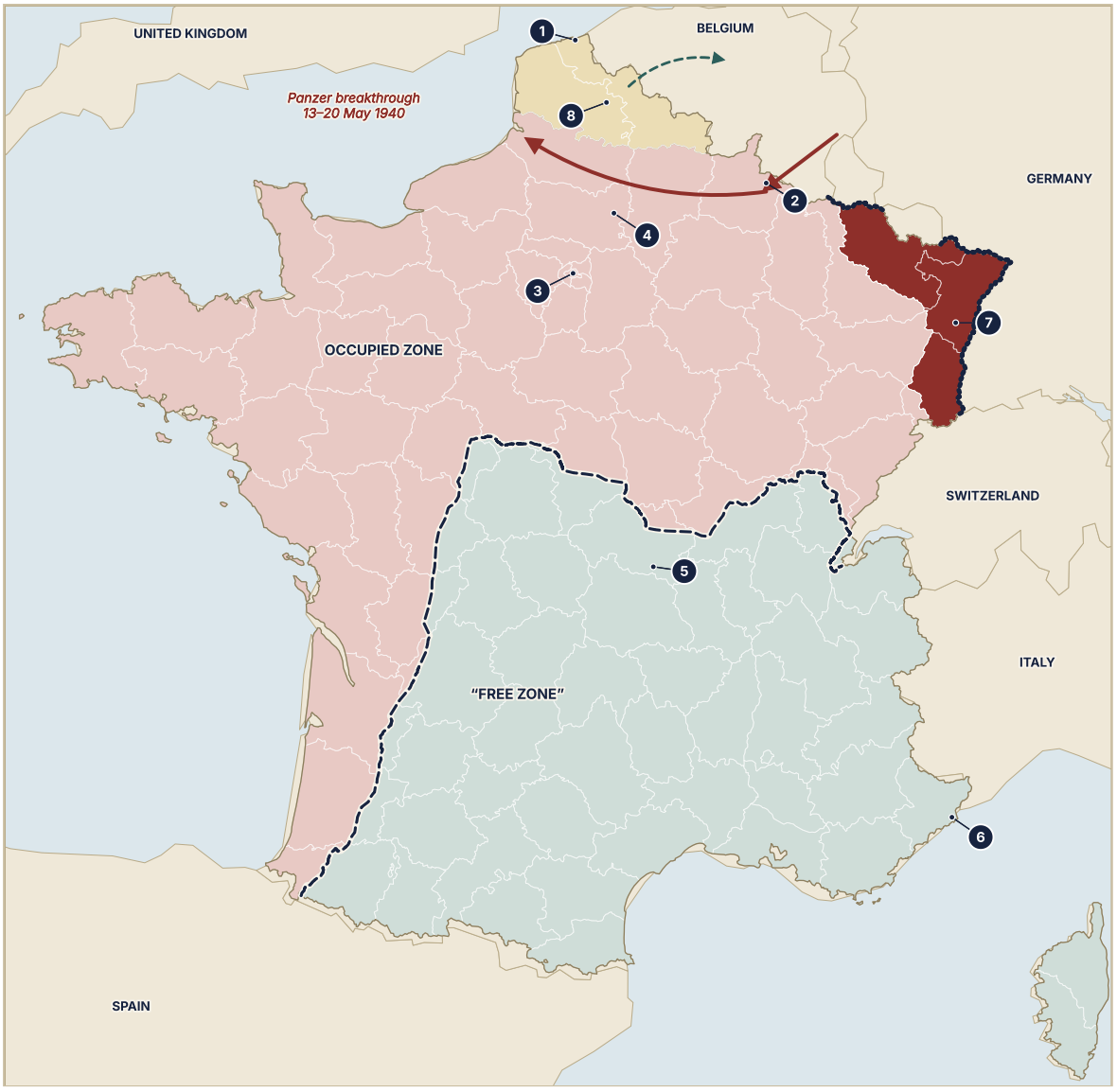
KEY TERMS

New European Order · Lebensraum

Summary diagram — The New European Order: the five driving forces announced in the introduction

1. Europe as a "racial entity": racial purification through genocide
2. The quest for Lebensraum in the East
3. A crusade against communism
4. The Grossraum: Europe as a single economic unit serving Germany
5. Supplying Germany with the people, materials and money required for total war

Summary map — France defeated and cut up (1940–1942)



- Occupied zone: three-fifths of the country, German Military Command (MBF)
- "Free zone", governed from Vichy until 11 Nov. 1942
- Alsace-Moselle, annexed: back to the borders of 1871
- Nord and Pas-de-Calais, attached to the German command in Brussels
- Demarcation line
- Maginot Line (schematic): it did not cover the Belgian border

1. Dunkirk, 26 May–4 June 1940: Operation Dynamo, 338,000 soldiers evacuated.
2. Sedan, 13–20 May 1940: the armoured breakthrough after the Ardennes; Rommel's 7th Panzer Division races to the Somme.
3. Paris, 14 June 1940: German troops enter; some 8 million people on the roads of the exodus.
4. Rethondes, 22 June 1940: the armistice; 1,850,000 French prisoners.
5. Vichy: seat of Marshal Pétain's authoritarian regime, which chose collaboration.
6. Italian zone: about 15 communes, mainly in the Alpes-Maritimes.
7. Alsace-Moselle: annexed and merged into German regions.
8. Nord and Pas-de-Calais: under the German Military Command in Brussels (MBB).

Red arrows: the German attack of May 1940; green dashes: the Allied advance into Belgium. Demarcation line: Département de l'Ain dataset (data.gouv.fr), drawn from the armistice documents.

Intro An ideological war, and the New European Order

The Second World War began before 1939

Many historians, including Jay Winter and Robert Frank, have shown that the war began before 1939, and its chronology can be stretched from 1931 to 1947. 1937 is the turning point: Japan attacked southern China, which immediately appealed to the League of Nations for help. The League proved incapable of regulating international tensions, which soon spread to a global scale.

> **EXAMPLE** Robert Frank and Alya Aglan titled their book La Guerre-monde 1937–1947 (2015): the dates on the cover are an argument in themselves. Japan's invasion of southern China in 1937 is the event that opens it.

A war to destroy the enemy's civilisation, not only to defeat its armies

Unlike other wars, the Second World War was not only about defeating the enemy on the battlefield but about destroying their civilisation. It was an ideological war, in which no side would give up until death, and its toll was without precedent. It was, in the course's words, the ideological crucible of the twentieth century.

> **EXAMPLE** The final death toll is about 60 million. M. Ros opens the chapter with a photograph of Einsatzgruppen killers shooting men standing in a pit, around 1941–1942, probably taken by one of the killers.

The New European Order (key term): Nazi rule over Europe, presented as saving it

For the Nazis, war and conquest were the opportunity to build a grandiose political and economic apparatus that would entrench their domination of Europe. Its supporters presented this New European Order as saving European civilisation from collapse. The chapter assesses its nature and purposes through five driving forces: Europe as a "racial entity" and racial purification through genocide; the quest for Lebensraum in the East; the crusade against communism; the Grossraum, a single European economic unit; and the need to supply Germany with the people, materials and money required for total war.

> **EXAMPLE** Hitler told the Reichstag on 11 December 1941 that this new order meant "the absolute elimination of the Jews, the establishment of the supremacy of the German people, and the creation of a real community of nations under German leadership".

I.1 Nazi invasion of Western Europe: the French case

1939–1941: the Axis overran continental Europe, and only Britain still resisted

Germany and the USSR were the two powers that attacked first, in 1939. By 1941 the Axis had made rapid progress: continental Europe was overcome, while the USSR had taken a share of eastern Europe. The only nation still resisting the Axis in 1941 was Britain. This is the situation the map of Europe 1939–1941 asks you to describe.

> **EXAMPLE** German troops overran Belgium, the Netherlands, Luxembourg and France in six weeks from May 1940; after France's armistice in June 1940, Great Britain was the only country still fighting Nazi Germany.

France had a huge army, but an old-fashioned defensive strategy

France had probably the biggest army in the world in 1940, but it was led by the victors of WWI and it was not very modern. France and Britain chose a defensive strategy: avoid a new trench war and its death toll, and withstand a massive German attack behind fortifications. From September 1939 to May 1940 little fighting took place in the west — the "phoney war".

> **EXAMPLE** France had 105 divisions in 1940, more than Britain's 34. The Maginot Line, a sophisticated chain of fortifications along the border with Germany, did not cover the Franco-Belgian border.

The Blitzkrieg: the main attack came through the Ardennes, where nobody expected it

Germany sought a rapid victory through the Blitzkrieg, the "lightning war" of tanks and aircraft. British and French commanders believed the Germans would attack through central Belgium, as in 1914, and rushed their best forces there. The main attack instead went through the hilly Ardennes forest in south-eastern Belgium and northern Luxembourg; German tanks broke through the French lines and advanced to the Channel coast.

> **EXAMPLE** The attack began on 10 May 1940, and the armoured breakthrough in the Ardennes came between 13 and 20 May. Erwin Rommel's 7th Panzer Division crossed the French countryside towards the Somme.

Dunkirk: the British saved their army, which the French lived as a betrayal

Trapped against the coast, the British Expeditionary Force organised a hasty evacuation by sea, Operation Dynamo. French troops saw it as a betrayal. But the evacuation left the Royal Navy and the RAF intact, and Churchill, newly appointed prime minister, insisted that Britain would fight on later with American aid.

> **EXAMPLE** Between 26 May and 4 June 1940, Operation Dynamo lifted 338,000 Allied soldiers from the beaches of Dunkirk to Britain. Churchill had become prime minister on 10 May, the very day of the German attack.

Defeat in six weeks: Paris fell, millions fled, and France signed an armistice

German forces launched a major offensive from the Somme towards Paris, and the French government fled the capital. Paris fell six weeks after the campaign began. The human cost was huge, and millions of panic-stricken civilians took to the roads towards the south. France signed an armistice, leaving Britain alone against Germany.

> **EXAMPLE** Paris fell on 14 June 1940 and the armistice was signed on 22 June at Rethondes, in the Compiègne forest. About 100,000 French soldiers died in combat, 200,000 were wounded and 1,850,000 were taken prisoner; some 8 million people joined the exodus.

France was cut into zones, each with a different master

Germany occupied three-fifths of mainland France — the areas with the highest economic potential and the Atlantic and northern coasts, to watch for any landing — under a German Military Command (MBF). A demarcation line separated it from the "free zone" governed from Vichy. Italy administered a small zone, the Nord and Pas-de-Calais were attached to the German command in Brussels, and Alsace and Moselle were annexed outright, restoring the borders of 1871.

> **EXAMPLE** About 15 communes, mainly in the Alpes-Maritimes, were administered by Italy. On 11 November 1942 German forces invaded the "free zone" in response to the Allied landing in French North Africa (Operation Torch).

Vichy: an authoritarian French state that chose to collaborate

The unoccupied zone came under a new government led by Marshal Pétain, established in the spa town of Vichy as an authoritarian regime. From the armistice onwards it sought collaboration with the German authorities. Although it was under Nazi pressure, it was often keen to collaborate, and it began persecuting Jews even before the Germans demanded it. General de Gaulle, who rejected the surrender, fled to Britain and set up a government in exile.

> **EXAMPLE** In October 1940 a Vichy decree defined who was a Jew and limited their place in French society; in March 1941 Vichy created an Office for Jewish Affairs — French initiatives, not German orders.

France was exploited to feed the German war machine, in money, goods and workers

The occupation was above all an economic exploitation. France had to pay heavy occupation fees, which financed German requisitions and the plundering of French resources — coal, food, fuel — leading to rationing and a black market. From 1942 the Service du travail obligatoire (STO), created by Vichy, sent French workers to Germany as forced labour.

> **EXAMPLE** France paid 20 million Reichsmarks a day in occupation fees. Under the STO laws of 1942–1943, all able-bodied men aged 18 to 50 and single women aged 21 to 35 could be sent; Germany promised to free one French prisoner of war for every three workers sent.

Jews were persecuted, dispossessed, then deported — by the occupier and by Vichy

In the occupied zone, Jews faced immediate persecution, comparable to that in Poland. Their businesses and property were confiscated under "Aryanisation" laws, leaving families without home or work. From June 1942 they had to wear the yellow star, and from the summer of 1942 they were arrested for deportation to the east — arrests carried out mainly by French police. From 1942, Jews were deported from the Vichy zone too.

> **EXAMPLE** About 350,000 Jews lived in France in 1940, more than half of them foreign refugees. Some 80,000 were deported during the war, and only about 3% of them survived. Note on the course: the lesson attributes the 1942 arrests to the Milice, but the Milice was only created in January 1943; the great round-up of July 1942 in Paris was the work of the French police.

Repression and seduction worked together: terror for opponents, flattery for the rest

Jews, communists and "terrorists" — the occupier's word for Resistance fighters — were targeted both by the Gestapo and by Vichy's police forces. At the same time the occupier tried to win the French over: German propaganda praised French culture, flattered French business and presented collaboration as the natural place of France in the new Europe.

> **EXAMPLE** The British weekly The Observer noted on 7 September 1941 that the German-run Pariser Zeitung presented Paris as the future holiday resort of the Nazi "Herrenvolk", and that "collaboration" was its daily theme — an attempt to win Paris "by flattery instead of by repression".

Conclusion on France: a special case that shows what the New European Order was for

France is a special case because decision-making was not unified: German occupation forces and French authorities coexisted. Repression and terror were used against opponents both by the Nazis and by Vichy; both implemented racist policies; and Germany used French territory and population to supply itself with the human, material and financial resources it needed for total war. That is the New European Order seen from one occupied country.

> **EXAMPLE** Three figures sum up the three dimensions: 20 million Reichsmarks a day (the money), the STO from 1942 (the workers), and some 80,000 Jews deported (the racial policy).

Key figures

Philippe Pétain
Marshal, head of the Vichy regime, which chose collaboration

Charles de Gaulle
General who refused the armistice and set up a government in exile in London

Winston Churchill
British prime minister from 10 May 1940, who kept Britain fighting alone

Erwin Rommel
Commander of the 7th Panzer Division in the 1940 Blitzkrieg

Robert Frank
Historian who dates the “world war” 1937–1947 (with Alya Aglan, 2015)

Numbers

~60 million
Dead in the Second World War

105
French divisions in 1940 — none left in 1942

338,000
Allied soldiers evacuated from Dunkirk

1,850,000
French soldiers taken prisoner in 1940

20 million
Reichsmarks a day paid by France in occupation fees

~80,000
Jews deported from France; about 3% survived

Vocabulary

THE WAR AND ITS AIMS

New European Order
Nazi rule over the continent, presented as saving European civilisation (key term).

Grossraum
“Great space”: the Nazi vision of Europe as a single economic unit serving Germany.

Einsatzgruppen
SS mobile killing units that shot civilians behind the Eastern Front.

Blitzkrieg
“Lightning war”: a rapid offensive combining tanks and aircraft.

phoney war
Sept. 1939–May 1940: war declared but almost no fighting in the west.

Maginot Line
French fortifications along the German border, not covering the Belgian one.

Operation Dynamo
Evacuation of 338,000 Allied soldiers from Dunkirk, 26 May–4 June 1940.

OCCUPIED FRANCE

armistice
Agreement ending the fighting, signed by France on 22 June 1940 at Rethondes.

demarcation line
The line separating the occupied zone from the “free zone” until November 1942.

Vichy regime
Marshal Pétain's authoritarian French state, based in Vichy, which chose collaboration.

collaboration
The policy of cooperating with the occupier, sought by Vichy from the armistice onwards.

government in exile
De Gaulle's French authority set up in London after the armistice.

STO
Forced sending of French workers to Germany, created by Vichy in 1942.

Aryanisation
Confiscation of Jewish businesses and property, handed to non-Jewish administrators.

exodus
The flight of some 8 million civilians southwards in May–June 1940.

black market
Illegal trade in rationed goods, fed by German requisitions.